

Some of these speaker sets are meant for your car, and plug into your car using a cigarette lighter adapter. Nokia sells one car kit for Rs 12,000—it comes with a phone stand, charger, speaker and the option of using the car's speakers or headset. The cheaper version has a charger with an inbuilt speaker for Rs 4,000.

Backup Your Data

Imagine losing your phone! More than the cost of a new phone, people cringe at the thought of having to re-enter those hundreds of contacts. What if you don't have a hard-copy backup of your contacts? Such disasters can be soothed by synching your phone with your PC. All you need is the manufacturer's software and a data cable.

Data cables from leading brands cost about Rs 1,600, though most higher-end phones come bundled with them. Though most phones can connect to a via IR and Bluetooth, most of us do not have computers with IR and Bluetooth ports, making data cables more popular. You can buy a USB to IR or USB to Bluetooth adapter for Rs 500 and Rs 1,000 respectively.

Certain high-end phones with SD I/O (Secure Digital Input/Output) interfaces, and no Bluetooth functionality, can use Bluetooth cards that look like SD memory cards to become Bluetooth-enabled. The same interface supports Wi-Fi cards and modems, too.

Powerless

Your standard phone charger is good for your home, office or hotel room. What if you are travelling by car and your batteries die? Buy a cigarette lighter car charger for your phone, which costs Rs 200. Now charge your phone using the car battery. Not everyone is a Nokia fan, and as a result, when leaving on a family trip, you have to pack three or four different phone chargers. This problem can be solved by buying a universal

There is another type of charger that uses your energy! Connect it to your phone and start winding. It gives you talktime and a great workout!

Why is it called Bluetooth?

Harald Bluetooth was king of Denmark in the late 900s. He managed to unite Denmark and part of Norway into a single kingdom and introduce Christianity into Denmark. He was killed in 986 during a battle with his son, Svend Forkbeard. Choosing this name for the standard indicates how important companies from the Baltic region (nations including Denmark, Sweden, Norway and Finland) are to the communications industry, even if it says little about the way the technology works.

charger, which has pins that connect to various phone brands, an all-in-one adapter, and costs a mere Rs 150.

Another cool accessory is the desk stand, which lets you charge your phone *sans* the hassles of attached wires—when the phone rings, the desk stand's speakers and mic let you accept the call without having to touch the phone.

What happens when you are out in the wilderness (read: away from a electric socket)? There is a charger that runs on three AAA cells and can restore enough power to your phone for about an hour of talk time or four hours of standby time. And all this for just Rs 120!

There is another charger that uses *your* energy! Connect it to your phone and start winding. It gives you talk time and a great workout! This product is yet to make an entry in India.

Signal Strength

If you travel to areas with low signal strength, or your operator has bad coverage, consider external antennas. These attach to your car roof, connect to your phone wirelessly, receive signals, amplify them, and then send them to your phone—the result is much higher clarity than normal.

Other Cellular Eye Candy

Almost all manufacturers offer external cameras that you can use independently. The Nokia Medallion costs Rs 8,000, can be worn around the neck, and displays the photos you click.

Nokia also has the Digital Pen, for approximately Rs 12,000. You can scribble notes and send handwritten personalised notes via MMS. Whatever you scribble is stored in the pen itself, and can later be transferred to a PC. It also boasts of Bluetooth and an integrated camera.

Another useful but quaint accessory is the Cell Socket. Connect your phone to its cradle and receive cell phone calls via your landline—like an EPABX system.

Another cool accessory is the Travel Pac Wireless Handsfree Kit, which connects to your phone speaker and beams the voice at any of two preset frequencies that you can catch on your car's FM radio using the car speakers as a hands-free kit!

This is just the beginning. Accessories are being invented by the thousands—just think of a way life could be easier, and accessorise! Not all the aforementioned accessories are readily available in India, but then again, what good are relatives who live abroad? ☒

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Using Bluetooth, you can achieve data transfer speeds of 1 Mbps between your devices